Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K Q J 10 7 5 ♥ A J 8 6 3 ♦ A ♣ 5	
♠ 9 6 4 2 ♥ 5 ♦ J 5 3 ♣ A K 9 7 4		♠ 3 ♥ 10 4 ♦ K Q 10 9 6 2 ♣ 10 8 6 2
	♠ A 8 ♥ K Q 9 7 2 ♦ 8 7 4 ♣ Q J 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	2♥
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♠[2]
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards with the trump queen

6♥ by South
Lead: ♣K

Since there has not been a clear agreement on the trump suit you can assume it is ♥s, the last bid suit.

So you have two Key-Cards (♠A and ♥K, along with the ♥Q). You therefore bid 5♠ and partner bids 6♥.

Board 2
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K Q J 5
♥ A Q J 3
♦ Q 6
♣ K Q J

♠ 8
♥ 10 7 4
♦ A K J 9
♣ 9 8 6 5 2

♠ 6 4
♥ 8 6 2
♦ 10 7 4 3 2
♣ 10 4 3

♠ A 10 9 7 3 2
♥ K 9 5
♦ 8 5
♣ A 7

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	4♠	Pass	5♣
Pass	5♥	Pass	5♠
All Pass			

5♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

Partner's jump to 4♠ indicates he is prepared to play at game even if you have as few as 6 points. So he must have 20 points or so. With your 14 that puts you in slam range.

Despite your conviction that this hand is going to slam you should **NOT** ask for Key-Cards holding a worthless doubleton. Instead, you make a slam try by bidding your cheapest control, 5♣. Partner says 5♥. What is your next bid?

You can only say 5♠. Partner would have control-bid ♦s if he held the Ace since controls are bid up-the-line. His failure to show it means he doesn't have it. Since you might be off the first two ♦ tricks you stop at 5♠.

Yes, partner should probably have opened 2NT. Sometimes partners don't make the bids you think they oughta.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

♠ J 10 8 7
♥ A 7
♦ A K 6 3
♣ A 8 2

♠ 5 3
♥ 10 3 2
♦ Q 9 7 4
♣ J 9 6 5

♠ A 4
♥ Q J 9 4
♦ J 10 8 2
♣ 10 7 4

♠ K Q 9 6 2
♥ K 8 6 5
♦ 5
♣ K Q 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♦[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 0 or 3 key cards

6♠ by South
Lead: ♥2

You have 3 Key-Cards so you bid 5♦. Partner bids 6♠.

Board 4
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K Q 8 4 ♥ A J 6 ♦ J 3 ♣ Q J 8 3	
♠ 10 6 ♥ 7 4 3 ♦ 10 9 8 7 4 ♣ 7 5 4		♠ 5 3 ♥ 10 9 8 2 ♦ A Q 6 2 ♣ 10 9 2
	♠ A J 9 7 2 ♥ K Q 5 ♦ K 5 ♣ A K 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♥	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♠[2]	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards with the trump queen

6♠ by South
Lead: ♣4

Your partnership plays Jacoby 2NT convention, so partner's 2NT shows a game-forcing raise in ♠s. Your 3NT bid indicates a 5-card suit and "extra values". Partner's 4♥ is a control-bid showing the ♥A.

What you need to know now about partner's hand is Key-Cards so you bid 4NT. He answers 5♠. What is your bid?

Partner's response says 2 Key-Cards and the ♠Q. So you are missing either the trump King or the ♦A. So you shouldn't bid 7, but you will almost surely make 6. You bid 6♠.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q ♥ 10 7 4 ♦ K J 6 3 ♣ K Q J 7	
♠ 8 6 2 ♥ K J 8 5 3 2 ♦ 9 4 ♣ 8 2		♠ 10 9 5 4 3 ♥ A Q 9 ♦ 2 ♣ 9 5 4 3
	♠ K J 7 ♥ 6 ♦ A Q 10 8 7 5 ♣ A 10 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♦	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♦
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards without the trump queen

6♦ by South
Lead: ♣8

Partner's 3♦ bid shows a very good hand with probable slam interest. It is very tempting to say 3NT now but you don't have ♥s stopped and don't know if partner does. So with good ♦ support you bid 4♦. Partner bids 4NT. What is your response?

You have 2 Key-Cards, the ♠A and ♦K. But you don't have the ♦Q so you answer 5♥. Partner bids 6♦.

Board 6
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 6 5 2 ♥ Q J 5 2 ♦ K J 3 ♣ 8 2	
♠ Q 9 7 4 ♥ 10 3 ♦ A Q 10 7 ♣ 10 6 5		♠ J 3 ♥ 7 ♦ 9 8 6 5 4 2 ♣ J 9 4 3
	♠ K 10 8 ♥ A K 9 8 6 4 ♦ — ♣ A K Q 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	4♣
Pass	4♥	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♣[2]	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

6♥ by South
Lead: ♠7

Your partner's 3♥ is a limit-raise, 11-12 points with ♥ support.

What you want to know is whether partner holds the ♠A. If you bid 4NT and he shows two Key-Cards all will be well, you will know they are the two missing Aces. But if he shows just 1 Key-Card you will be in the soup since you can't tell if that Key-Card is the useful ♠A or the practically useless ♦A. So you don't use RKCB, you use control-showing and bid 4♣. Partner says 4♥.

Partner would have control-bid ♦s if he had the Ace. You may not think that helps but it does since now you can bid RKCB. You bid 4NT and he answers 5♣. What is your next bid?

It was a lot of work but you have figured out that partner holds 11-12 points including one Key-Card which must be the ♠A. It looks like the slam is a good idea so you say 6♥.

Board 7
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K 8 6 5 2 ♥ K J 10 7 ♦ — ♣ A 9 8 3	
♠ 10 3 ♥ Q 9 2 ♦ K Q 8 7 5 ♣ 10 7 2		♠ J ♥ A 6 5 4 3 ♦ J 10 9 4 ♣ 6 5 4
	♠ A Q 9 7 4 ♥ 8 ♦ A 6 3 2 ♣ K Q J	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	4♦	Pass	4NT
Pass	5NT	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

6♠ by South
Lead: ♦K

Your 4♦ bid is a Splinter Bid, showing opening hand strength, at least 4 ♠s, and a singleton or void in ♦s. Partner bids 4NT.

You have 2 Key-Cards, the ♠K and the ♣A. So do you bid 5♥?

No. You have two Key-Cards **AND** a void. So you bid 5NT. Partner bids 6♠.

Board 8
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 10 8 ♥ K 9 8 4 ♦ K 9 ♣ K 10 6 5	
♠ 3 2 ♥ J 3 2 ♦ 8 7 6 4 3 ♣ 8 4 3	N W E S	♠ 9 7 6 5 4 ♥ Q 5 ♦ 10 5 2 ♣ A 7 2
	♠ K Q J ♥ A 10 7 6 ♦ A Q J ♣ Q J 9	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards without the trump queen

5♥ by South
Lead: ♠3

Your partner's 2NT opener is 20-21 points and the 3♣ bid is Stayman.

You know of 33 points and you know of an 8-card ♥ fit. The math tells you that 6♥ should be a good slam but you might as well check Key-Cards, that's why the convention was invented. So you bid 4NT and partner answers 5♥.

You say "Darn!" You are missing just one Key-Card, but you are also missing the trump Queen. And with partner holding only a 4-card suit that Queen might well win a trick. Knowing that at best the slam will depend on a trump finesse you pass 5♥.

Board 9
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A K Q J
♥ A J 10 7
♦ A 5
♣ K Q 10

♠ 5 3 2
♥ 4 3
♦ J 9 6 2
♣ A 7 6 4

♠ 10 9 8 6 4
♥ 6 2
♦ 10 8 3
♣ J 5 2

♠ 7
♥ K Q 9 8 5
♦ K Q 7 4
♣ 9 8 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♣[2]
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

6♥ by South
Lead: ♣A

With 11 points and a good suit you should make a positive response. So you bid 2♥. Partner then says 4NT. What is your bid?

The 4NT bid agrees ♥s as trump. You have one Key-Card, the ♥K, so you bid 5♣. Partner bids the ♥ slam.

Board 10
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K 10 ♥ A K 9 8 4 ♦ K Q 8 ♣ K Q 6	
♠ 6 4 ♥ J 7 2 ♦ J 10 5 2 ♣ A 10 9 3	N W E S	♠ 9 8 2 ♥ Q 10 3 ♦ 9 7 6 ♣ J 7 5 4
	♠ A Q J 7 5 3 ♥ 6 5 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♠
Pass	3♥	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♠[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards with the trump queen

6♠ by South
Lead: ♦J

The bidding has been as shown.

Your partner has shown a minimum opening hand, but with 6 ♠s. You are happy with the 8-card trump fit but need to know about Key-Cards. So you bid 4NT. Partner answers 5♠ and it is your bid again.

Partner has two Aces and the ♠Q. That should be all he needs to make slam so you bid 6♠.

Board 11
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K Q J ♥ A Q 10 4 3 ♦ A J 8 ♣ 7	
♠ 5 3 ♥ 6 ♦ 10 9 6 5 ♣ A 9 8 6 3 2		♠ 10 9 8 ♥ 7 2 ♦ 3 2 ♣ K Q J 10 5 4
	♠ 7 6 4 2 ♥ K J 9 8 5 ♦ K Q 7 4 ♣ —	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	4NT	Pass	6♣
Pass	7♥		
All Pass			

7♥ by South
Lead: ♣A

With 11 points and a good suit you should make a positive response. So you bid 2♥. Partner then says 4NT. What is your bid?

The 4NT bid agrees ♥s as trump. You have one Key-Card, the ♥K, but you also have a void in ♣s. You therefore answer 6♣. Partner goes all the way to 7♥.

Board 12
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 6 5 2 ♥ A Q 7 4 ♦ K 8 6 ♣ A Q	
♠ Q J 8 ♥ 5 3 2 ♦ A 9 7 ♣ 8 6 5 2	N W E S	♠ 4 3 ♥ 9 8 6 ♦ 5 4 2 ♣ 10 9 7 4 3
	♠ A 10 9 7 ♥ K J 10 ♦ Q J 10 3 ♣ K J	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♣[2]
Pass	5♦	Pass	5♠
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

5♠ by South
Lead: ♣5

The bidding has been as shown.

Partner has 15-17 points and 4 ♠s. You have 18 points and 4 ♠s. You plan to bid the slam, but first you check Key-Cards. So you bid 4NT. Partner says 5♣.

You are missing 1 Key-Card. Slam has become less certain. You decide to see if partner has the trump Queen so you bid 5♦. Partner bids 5♠. What do you say next?

Partner denies having the ♠Q. Knowing that the best you could hope for would be a finesse to make the slam you give up your quest and pass.

Board 13
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ A K Q J 3 ♥ 10 8 7 5 ♦ K ♣ K Q J	
♠ 8 5 4 ♥ J 4 3 ♦ J 8 6 ♣ 10 9 8 2	N W E S	♠ 10 6 2 ♥ Q 2 ♦ 10 5 3 2 ♣ 7 6 4 3
	♠ 9 7 ♥ A K 9 6 ♦ A Q 9 7 4 ♣ A 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♦
Pass	1♠	Pass	2♥
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♣[2]
Pass	5♦	Pass	5♥
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

6♥ by South
Lead: ♠4

Your 2♥ bid is a Reverse, showing 17+ points.

There has been no agreement on trumps, so you assume that North has implicitly agreed to ♥s. So you respond 5♣, showing 4 Key-Cards, three Aces and the ♥K. Partner next bids 5♦.

5♦ is the Queen Ask. Partner obviously is thinking about a Grand Slam and wants to know whether you hold the trump Queen (♥Q). Since you do not have the card you return to the agreed trump suit at the lowest level - which is 5♥. Partner now bids 6♥.

Board 14
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 6 3
♥ A K 9 8 6 5
♦ K
♣ A 3 2

♠ 10 9 8 4
♥ 10 4 2
♦ 2
♣ J 10 9 7 5

♠ Q J 5 2
♥ 7
♦ 9 6 4 3
♣ Q 8 6 4

♠ K 7
♥ Q J 3
♦ A Q J 10 8 7 5
♣ K

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♣[2]	Pass	5NT[3]
Pass	6♦	Pass	7NT
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards
3. asks for kings

7NT by South
Lead: ♣J

The bidding has been as shown. Yes, you could have jump-shifted on your first bid.

Slam in ♥s is almost certain, but you should check for Key-Cards. You bid 4NT and partner says 5♣.

Partner shows 1 or 4 Key-cards. Since he jumped on the second round you figure it must be 4. So you have all the Key-Cards. Time to find out about the other Kings, so you bid 5NT. Partner replies 6♦.

Partner has 1 King, the only one left, the ♦K. You can count about 17 high-card tricks available so you bid 7NT.

Board 15
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ — ♥ A 10 9 6 ♦ K Q J 7 4 ♣ J 10 8 3	
♠ K Q 7 3 ♥ 7 4 ♦ A 6 5 3 2 ♣ 9 4		♠ A J 9 5 4 2 ♥ 5 2 ♦ 9 8 ♣ 7 5 2
	♠ 10 8 6 ♥ K Q J 8 3 ♦ 10 ♣ A K Q 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

6♥ by South
Lead: ♠K

Your 3♠ bid is a Splinter, agreeing ♥s as trump, and showing opening hand strength with a singleton or void in ♠s.

You have one Key-Card, the ♥A. You also have a ♠ void, but since bidding 6♠ would take you above the 6♥ level you just respond 6♥. Partner will deduce that your void is in ♠s, particularly because you Splintered in that suit. Partner passes your 6♥ bid.

Board 16
East Deals
None Vul

♠ A 10 8 4 3
♥ Q 10 8 4
♦ —
♣ K J 10 2

♠ 2
♥ 9 5 3 2
♦ A Q J 10 4
♣ Q 9 8

♠ 7
♥ J 7 6
♦ K 9 6 3 2
♣ 7 6 4 3

♠ K Q J 9 6 5
♥ A K
♦ 8 7 5
♣ A 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♠
Pass	4♦	Pass	4NT
Pass	6♦	Pass	7♠
All Pass			

7♠ by South
Lead: ♥3

Partner's 4♦ bid is a Splinter Bid. It shows opening hand strength, at least 4-card ♠ support, and a singleton or void in ♦s.

Normally you would not ask for Key-Cards with this ♦ holding. But since you know partner has at most a singleton, and that it is not the singleton ♦A, you are safe to do so. You say 4NT, partner replies 6♦. What next?

WOW! Partner has one Key-Card and a ♦ void. So the Key-Card is the ♠A. You don't know what the rest of partner's hand is, but he can surely take care of that small ♣. You bid 7♠.

Board 17
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ 4 ♦ A K 10 8 6 3 ♣ A K Q	
♠ 10 4 3 ♥ K Q 8 7 2 ♦ J ♣ 9 7 6 5	N W E S	♠ J 9 6 2 ♥ J 9 5 3 ♦ 5 2 ♣ 4 3 2
	♠ K 8 7 ♥ A 10 6 ♦ Q 9 7 4 ♣ J 10 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	4♦
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♣[2]
Pass	5♥	Pass	5♠
Pass	7NT		
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 1 or 4 key cards

7NT by South
Lead: ♥K

Your 2NT response shows 8+ points, with no 5-card biddable suit.

You support the ♦s and partner bids 4NT. What is your next bid?

With ♦s as trump you have 1 Key-Card, the ♥A. You answer 5♣ and partner bids 5♥. What is your bid?

This is the Queen Ask, wanting to know if you hold the ♦Q. Since you do have it you should bid a suit in which you hold a King. So you bid 5♠. That spurred partner on - he was fishing for 7♦ but when you told him you had the ♦Q, ♥A and ♠K he was able to bid 7NT.

Board 18
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ Q 8
♥ A J 9 7
♦ K Q J
♣ A K Q 6

♠ 10 9 7 4 3
♥ 4
♦ 10 9 6 2
♣ 9 4 3

♠ A K J 6 5 2
♥ 5
♦ A 8 7 4
♣ 7 5

♠ —
♥ K Q 10 8 6 3 2
♦ 5 3
♣ J 10 8 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

6♥ by South
Lead: ♦10

Partner's 2♥ is a positive response, 8+ points with a 5+ card suit.

Even though it is tempting, bidding RKCB now would be a mistake because of your doubleton ♠ loser. Instead just support the ♥s. Partner cannot pass, you both know you are forced to game. In fact, partner bids 3♠.

Partner promises first round ♠ control so NOW you can bid RCKB. When you bid 4NT partner answers 6♥. This shows 1 Key-Card and a void in a suit higher than ♥s. Knowing you are missing either the ♦A or ♥K you pass.

Board 19
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K 10 7 2 ♥ A K 8 6 5 ♦ 8 3 ♣ 6 4	
♠ 6 ♥ Q 4 3 ♦ Q J 7 5 2 ♣ Q J 8 3		♠ 9 ♥ J 10 9 2 ♦ 10 9 6 ♣ 10 9 7 5 2
	♠ A Q J 8 5 4 3 ♥ 7 ♦ A K 4 ♣ A K	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♣
Pass	2♥	Pass	2♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	5NT[3]
Pass	6♦	Pass	7NT
All Pass			

1. Roman Key Card Blackwood
2. 2 key cards without the trump queen
3. asks for kings

7NT by South
Lead: ♦5

Your 2♥ response shows 8+ points, with at least 5 ♥s.

Your hand is looking better and better. You already gave a positive response so you know you are forced to game. It is better to keep the bidding low to allow more investigating room so you bid 3♠. Partner bids 4NT. What is your response?

With ♠s agreed as trumps you have two Key-Cards, the ♠K and the ♥A. With no trump Queen you respond 5♥. Partner now says 5NT. What do you reply?

Partner is asking for Kings and you have just 1, the ♥K. Remember, the ♠K is not a King, it is a Key-Card which you have already counted. So you bid 6♦. Partner counts 13 tricks and bids 7NT.

Board 20
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q J 7 3 ♥ A 8 ♦ 10 8 6 4 ♣ K J 5	
♠ 10 ♥ 10 7 5 3 ♦ 9 5 3 ♣ A Q 10 7 6		♠ 8 2 ♥ J 9 4 2 ♦ A 7 ♣ 9 8 4 3 2
	♠ A K 9 6 5 4 ♥ K Q 6 ♦ K Q J 2 ♣ —	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♠
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♣
Pass	4♥	Pass	6♠
All Pass			

6♠ by South
Lead: ♦3

Partner's 3♠ is a limit raise, 11-12 points and good ♠ support.

What you DO NOT say next is 4NT. If partner answered 1 Key-Card you would not know what to do. If he has a red Ace you can make slam, but if his one Key-Card were the ♣A you couldn't. Instead you make a control-showing bid of 4♣, promising first round control. Partner obliges you by bidding 4♥. What is your next bid?

Partner's bidding is like the Sherlock Holmes tale Silver Blaze, about the dog that didn't bark. Partner's ♥ bid shows that he **DOES** have the ♥A, but equally important it shows that he **DOES NOT** have the ♦A. So you know you don't have a ♥ loser but do have a ♦ loser. You bid 6♠.